

The KSL Crisis Leadership Framework

A practitioner's guide for fragile and conflict-affected settings

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1. Why crisis leadership is different

Conventional leadership theory assumes stable institutions, reliable information, and predictable stakeholder behaviour. Crisis settings invert all three. Effective leaders in fragile contexts operate with partial information, contested legitimacy, and rapidly shifting coalitions — and must still produce trust, direction, and delivery.

2. The four pillars

Clarity — articulate a 90-day mission that anyone in the organisation can repeat.

Cadence — a fixed rhythm of decisions and reviews that absorbs shocks without paralysis.

Coalition — explicit mapping of who must be aligned for each decision, and how their support will be earned.

Conscience — public, written principles that bound what the institution will and will not do under pressure.

3. The first 30 days

Stabilise information flow before issuing directives. The most common failure mode is leaders who broadcast strategy before they have a working sense of what their own institution actually does day-to-day. Build a one-page operating picture, then act.

4. Building accountability that survives transitions

Accountability mechanisms tied to a single leader collapse when that leader rotates. Durable accountability is procedural, documented, and externally legible — citizens, donors, and oversight bodies can verify outcomes without insider access.

5. Where this framework comes from

This framework is drawn from doctoral research on public-sector leadership in South Sudan and East Africa, combined with direct advisory engagements with ministries, oversight institutions, and development partners.

Want to discuss how this applies to your institution? Book a complimentary 60-minute discovery call at kslgroup.co/contact or write to info@kslgroup.co.

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